APOORVA BABBAR

DEPARTMENT OF ECONOMICS
University of Calgary | 2500 University Drive N.W., Calgary, Alberta T2N 1N4
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DOCTORAL STUDIES

University of Calgary
PhD, Economics, 2020 - 2027 (expected)
(family emergency leave from 2022 - 2024)

DISSERTATION COMMITTEE AND REFERENCES

Alexander Whalley (Chair)
Professor
Department of Economics
University of Calgary
alexander.whalley@ucalgary.ca

Trevor Tombe
Professor
Department of Economics
University of Calgary
ttombe@ucalgary.ca

Jean-William Laliberté
Associate Professor
Department of Economics
University of Calgary
jeanwilliam.lalibert@ucalgary.ca

PRIOR EDUCATION

Delhi School of Economics - Masters, Economics | 2015 – 2017
Hansraj College, University of Delhi - BA, Economics | 2012 – 2015

CITIZENSHIP

Citizenship: India

LANGUAGES

Hindi (native), English (fluent), French (basic)

FIELDS

Research: Labor Economics, Innovation, and Financial Economics
Teaching: Microeconomics, Macroeconomics, Economics of AI

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Guest Lecture, University of Calgary | 2026
Economics of AI

Sessional Instructor, University of Calgary | 2024
Principles of Macroeconomics

Graduate Teaching Assistant, University of Calgary
Principles of Microeconomics (2022, 2025); Principles of Macroeconomics (2022, 2023); Engineering Economics (2022); Managerial and Decision Economics (2021)

RELEVANT POSITIONS

Graduate Research Manager and Assistant, University of Calgary
Alexander Whalley (2022 - present); Trevor Tombe (2021, 2022)

Consumer Credit Associate, Risk Management, Wells Fargo, India | 2017 - 2020

FELLOWSHIPS, HONORS, AND AWARDS

Mitacs Globalink Research Award (CAD 6,000) | 2025
Eyes High International Doctoral Scholarship (CAD 15,000) | 2025 – 2026; 2024 - 2025
Battle for Alberta II, ACLMR, Graduate Student Winner | 2024
Victor Yang Song Award for Teaching Excellence, Department of Economics | 2024
3 Minute Thesis Presentation (Heats) - People's Choice Award | 2024
James D. Gaisford Best Second Year Paper Prize, Department of Economics | 2024
Alberta Graduate Excellence Scholarship - International (CAD 15,000) | 2022 - 2023
Microeconomics Prize, Department of Economics | 2021
International Graduate Tuition Award (CAD 3,100 per year) | 2020 - 2026

RESEARCH VISITS

Visiting Researcher, University of Oxford | Michaelmas 2025
Professor Renée Adams, Saïd Business School

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

Society of Labor Economists (SOLE), Denver | 2026
Canadian Women Economics Committee, Brown Bag Seminar | 2026
Interdisciplinary Doctoral Seminar, Saïd Business School, University of Oxford | 2025
Canadian Economic Association Conference, Montréal (Invitation) | 2025
Labor Economics Workshop, Alberta Centre for Labor Market Research | 2024
Canadian Economic Association Conference, Toronto | 2024

PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITIES

Peer Helper, Women Resource Centre, University of Calgary | 2021 - 2025
Gold and Bronze Recognitions for Outstanding Contributions
Mentor, Global Community Challenge YYC, University of Calgary | 2021, 2022, 2023
VP Social, Economics Graduate Association, University of Calgary | 2020 - 2025

SOFTWARE

Proficient: Stata, Codex, Linux
Working knowledge: R, Python, SAS

RESEARCH PAPERS

Gender Differences in AI Leadership: Evidence from Investor Reactions
Job Market Paper

This paper examines whether CEO gender is associated with how investors price information about leadership during times of technological uncertainty. Using artificial intelligence (AI) as the source of technological shift, I measure firms' AI-intensity from their occupational composition and estimate stock market reactions to 60 different AI news events from 2022 to 2025. Following AI news originating from social media or online channels, high AI-intensity firms earn returns 0.5 to 1 percentage points higher than low AI-intensity firms. This AI-intensity premium is approximately 1.2 percentage points larger for firms with female CEOs. These patterns suggest that online news channels may shape how investors price AI-intensity differently for female and male CEOs.

Public R&D and the Automation of Manufacturing: Evidence from the Space Race
With Alexander Whalley, Shawn Kantor, and Jingyuan Zeng
NBER Working Paper No. w35966; Submitted

This paper examines how public research and development shaped the direction of technological change during the Cold War–era Space Race and its consequences for US manufacturing. While prior research has documented the effects of public R&D on

innovation and economic growth, less is known about whether mission-oriented public investment directed innovation toward automation and how this affected labor markets. We exploit variation in exposure to NASA's Space Race investments across industries and locations to estimate the effects of public R&D on innovation and manufacturing outcomes from 1947 to 1992. Combining newly developed measures of automation in full-text patent data with historical evidence on government involvement in patenting, we show that NASA-sponsored patents are systematically more automation-intensive than non-NASA patents within the same technological classes. Industries and locations more exposed to Space Race activity experienced persistent declines in labor share, consistent with the diffusion of labor-saving technologies developed for space applications. In contrast, we find little evidence of systematic changes in skill composition. These findings show that mission-oriented public R\&D can shape the direction of technological change and have lasting distributional consequences.

Gendered Work Norms and Migration: Impact on Female Labor Force Participation
Revise and Resubmit, Economic Development and Cultural Change

This paper examines how exposure to gendered work norms impacts female labor force participation by exploiting migration as a source of variation in norms. I use novel global census data of 1.8 million migrants from 75 countries to test whether female labor market outcomes are driven by assimilation to destination norms or persistence of origin norms. I employ a fixed-effects model on movers who made the same move- from the same origin to the same destination but differ only in the duration of exposure to destination because they moved at different ages. I find asymmetric assimilation effects under key assumptions: movements from restrictive to female-supportive gendered work norms lead to an increase in female labor force participation over time, consistent with assimilation. However, moving to a country with restrictive gendered norms does not reduce female labor force participation, suggesting persistence of origin norms. In contrast, male labor force participation remains unchanged due to variation in norms. The results are robust to alternative specifications in my study: samples of forced migrants in conflicts and married females to eliminate any potential selection bias in migration decisions.